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Stanwood reactivates Flock cameras as Spokane County joins Pierce County in shutting them down



(Flock Safety)

By [Julia Dallas,](#)
[MyNorthwest.com](#)

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Washington cities and counties are changing their automated license plate reader (ALPR) policies in response to a [new law](#) regulating technology.

The City of Stanwood has decided to reactivate its Flock Safety cameras, while Spokane County has joined Pierce County in shutting them down.

Stanwood's Flock Camera System will be reactivated later this month following Washington Governor Bob Ferguson's signing of the Driver Privacy Act, according to a [news release](#) from the City of Stanwood.

The Driver Privacy Act, or [Senate Bill 6002](#), requires agencies to delete most license plate data within 21 days, prohibits data collection near schools and immigration facilities, and restricts sharing information with out-of-state or federal agencies. Violations could result in gross misdemeanor charges and penalties under the Consumer Protection Act.

Stanwood cameras were deactivated in May to comply with the evolving legal requirements. Now, the city is reinstating the camera system in alignment with the new law. Stanwood currently has 14 Flock cameras along major routes entering and exiting the city. City officials noted that any cameras that don't meet the requirements will remain inactive and be relocated.

"I'm pleased that the legislature overwhelmingly recognized the value of keeping residents safer through technology on the one hand while balancing the need to impose guardrails that help protect privacy rights on the other," Stanwood Mayor Sid Roberts stated in the release.

The City of Stanwood praised Flock cameras for helping officers respond more quickly and efficiently to crimes. The cameras help Stanwood police solve property crimes, find stolen cars, identify cars linked to criminal activity, and aid in missing persons cases.

“We are committed to following state law while balancing public safety and individual privacy,” Stanwood Police Chief Glenn DeWitt stated. “These tools help further safeguard our city while ensuring we respect the rights and expectations of our community.”

City officials noted police do not use Flock cameras for immigration enforcement, traffic enforcement, harassment, or personal use. They added that under the new law, data collected by the system will only be retained for 21 days, and that access is strictly limited to authorized law enforcement.

Spokane County shuts down Flock cameras over legal risk

Meanwhile, other jurisdictions in Washington are so frustrated with the new law that they have decided to shut down the camera system entirely. The Spokane County Sheriff’s Office (SCSO) announced Wednesday [via Facebook](#) that it is deactivating its ALPR technology and associated systems.

“This new state law imposes significant restrictions on ALPR systems, some of which were ill-considered, leading us to make this difficult decision,” SCSO stated in its post. “We are assessing how we continue using this crucial law enforcement tool inside the boundaries set by this new law. We did not make this choice lightly, and we believe the legislation as passed is making our community less safe.”

The sheriff’s office called it a difficult decision, acknowledging that ALPR technology has proven highly effective in solving crimes, apprehending violent offenders, finding missing people, and locating stolen vehicles and suspects. Ultimately, however, authorities said the legal risk was too great to continue using the cameras as deputies could be charged with a gross misdemeanor.

Spokane County Sheriff John Nowels said he is going to continue working with lawmakers to find a solution.

“I believe some in the legislature had good intentions, but unfortunately, it seems they did not completely understand ALPR technology, how effective it is, or the many ways it is used and not used,” Nowels stated. “These imposed restrictions have made it nearly impossible for law enforcement agencies across the State of Washington to continue using ALPR systems as currently designed and implemented, and that is unacceptable. I will continue to work with legislators and other law enforcement

organizations to help find a reasonable solution to the unintended consequences that I believe make our community less safe.”

Pierce County sheriff says ALPR system is now useless

Back in western Washington, [Pierce County Sheriff Keith Swank](#) has also decided to deactivate his entire ALPR system, claiming it’s now useless.

“We could be driving past stolen cars, cars that have a suspect wanted for homicide,” Swank told KIRO Newsradio. “Those cameras help us differentiate those cars, the bad guys, from the good guys, and we won’t be able to use that tool anymore.”

Swank argued the restrictions are impossible to comply with, specifically the ban on cameras near protected places like schools and hospitals, because in-car cameras can’t be turned off manually.

Supporters argue the law is needed to protect immigrant communities from federal enforcement and community privacy.

Contributing: Frank Lenzi and Jillian Raftery, KIRO Newsradio

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Three smartphones are shown, displaying the KIRO 7 app. The main phone shows the KIRO 7 logo and the tagline 'LIVE. LOCAL. IN-DEPTH.' Below it, there's a weather forecast for Seattle on Monday, September 28, 2015, with a temperature of 69° and a sun icon.

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LINKS ON TV

A large white link icon (two interlocking circles) is shown, with a white hand cursor pointing at it. The background is a dark blue image of a news studio with a KIRO 7 logo on a screen.

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